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THE GROWTH OF THE RSS

In October 2000, I was reporting on a massive three-day camp to celebrate seventy-five years of the founding of the RSS.[1] The Rashtriya Raksha Mahashivir (Great National Security Camp), set up near the Mughal emperor Akbar's tomb on the outskirts of Agra, brought together the Sangh's top brass and over 75,000 volunteers from sixteen districts in the Braj prant (region) of western UP. They were put up in a specially constructed tent city spread over 400 acres and divided into thirty-five townships. This was a year after the Kargil War, and so, the giant main gate to the tent city, christened Mahabalipuram (Great Warrior Abode), replicated an iconic war photo of victorious Indian soldiers flying the tricolour on top of an imposing mountain peak that the Indian Army had recaptured in that war with Pakistan. Inside the tent city, the centre-point was another massive tableau: of Lord Krishna holding aloft Mount Govardhan on his little finger (depicting a story from the Krishna legend set in nearby Vrindavan).

Over the next three days, a number of the Vajpayee government's leading lights visited the camp. Some of them, including Deputy Prime Minister L.K. Advani and UP Chief Minister Ram Prakash Gupta, standing prominently in the front row during public meetings, performed the rhythmic RSS salute (with right hand folded at chest-level, palm next to the heart and facing downwards) and its customary Sanskrit prayer to the Motherland.[2] A few of these visiting dignitaries addressed the gathered thousands in the mid-day heat, talking about the vital role that the RSS had played in their lives. Advani told the audience that the 'RSS exercises a moral